the border, was deceitful in negotiations, and was spoiling for war. In fact, none of those propositions is particularly correct. Charles Glaser, the American political scientist, has suggested that international conflict often arises because of 'greedy' countries that are aggressive-minded and expansionist.[1] All countries want to protect their territory, are sometimes deceitful, and will take decisions to go to war, but India–China interactions in these thirteen years were not the interactions between two greedy countries or even between one greedy and one more moderate country. Instead, they were both security-seeking countries that, as in a Greek tragedy, came to see the other as greedy, expansionist, and aggressive.

Contrary to a now quite prevalent view on both sides that the other was looking for a fight over the border, India and China were initially hesitant to raise the issue of conflicting territorial claims. When they finally did engage each other directly on the subject, they saw contradictions and inconsistencies in the other's statements and actions. Delhi and Beijing also had deep differences over imperially defined boundaries that tipped them into outright disagreement over the border: India wanted to honour inherited boundaries whereas China wanted to renegotiate them. The border problem was intimately connected to the status of Tibet. Both countries concluded, particularly after the Tibetan rebellion of 1956–59, that the other had failed to honour its commitments. India felt China had reversed course on Tibet's autonomy, and China felt India had reverted to a policy of interference in the province. Finally, both also regarded their own military moves in the Himalaya between 1949 and 1962 as being defensive and the other side's moves as being aggressive.

Hesitations

India's prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru and his foreign policy team are often faulted for being dreamy-eyed idealists in international affairs, with a penchant for thinking about what should be rather than what is and failing to adopt even normal precautions on the border with China. In fact, though,